Nagasura Timan Madale

Nagasura Timan Madale (born February 1942, Marawi City) is a Meranaw cultural anthropologist, peace educator, and one of the most respected voices in Bangsamoro intellectual life.

A professor of cultural anthropology at Mindanao State University for several decades, he devoted his career to two intertwined missions: recovering the deep literary and ritual traditions of the Maranao people from the margins of Philippine scholarship, and then turning that recovered heritage into practical tools for conflict resolution and interfaith dialogue in Mindanao.

He is perhaps best known outside academic circles for founding the *School for the Living Tradition* under the National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA), and for leading the Access Philippines Youth Leadership Training Program, a U.S. Department of State-funded initiative that brought Muslim, Christian, and Lumad youth from Mindanao to Northern Illinois University for intensive peace and mediation training.

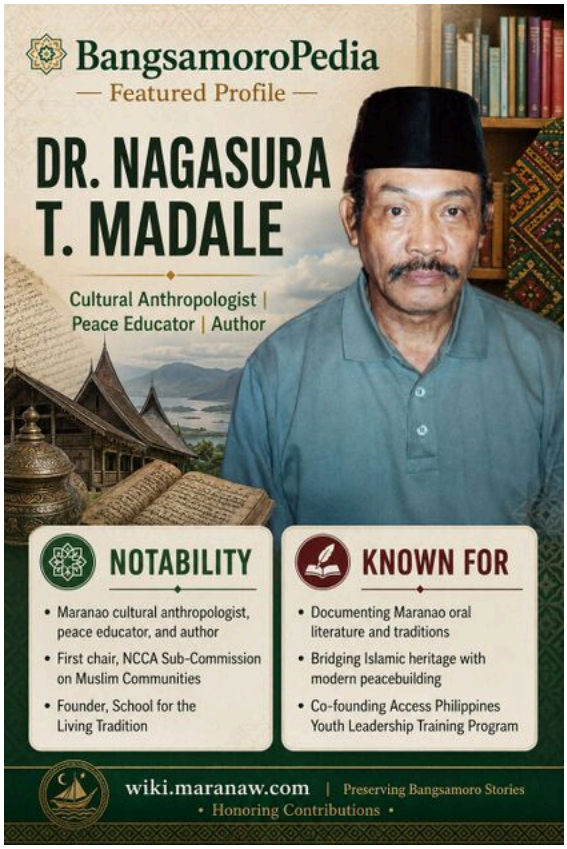
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EARLY LIFE AND ROOTS

Nagasura Timan Madale was born in Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, the cultural and political heartland of the Meranaw people, in February 1942.

DR. NAGASURA T. MADALE



Personal Information

Born: February 1942
Marawi City, Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Ethnicity

Meranaw (Maranao)

Education

B.S. in Elementary Education, Mindanao State University, 1968
M.A. in Asian Studies, University of the

He is the son of Serapion A. Madale and Faidah T. Madale, and grew up in a community where Islamic faith, customary law, and oral tradition were not separate categories but woven into the fabric of everyday life.

Lake Lanao, the body of water that defines Meranaw identity (the name literally means "people of the lake"), shaped his earliest intellectual instincts: a sense that the rhythms of oral poetry, the rules of *adat* and *taritib* (customary law and protocol), and the imperatives of *maratabat* (honor and dignity) were not quaint survivals but living, functioning frameworks with real explanatory power.

That sensibility, that the indigenous was not inferior to the imported but was in fact irreplaceable, would run through everything he wrote and built for the next six decades.

EDUCATION

Madale completed his Bachelor of Science in Elementary Education at Mindanao State University in Marawi City in 1968.

He then moved to Quezon City to pursue graduate studies at the University of the Philippines Diliman, earning his Master of Arts in Asian Studies in 1973.

His doctoral work at the same institution, completed in 1987, earned him a Ph.D. in Philippine Studies, with a research focus on the oral literature and cultural anthropology of Mindanao's Muslim communities.

In between those milestones, he pursued further scholarly formation internationally: a postdoctoral fellowship in nonviolence studies at the Inter-University Center for Postdoctoral Studies in Dubrovnik, Yugoslavia in 1983, and a Folklore Fellowship at the Finnish Academy of Sciences and Letters in 1991.

These fellowships signaled that his work was being recognized well beyond the Philippines, and they gave him comparative frameworks for thinking about indigenous oral traditions and conflict resolution that he would bring back to Mindanao.

Philippines Diliman, 1973
Ph.D. in Philippine Studies, University of the Philippines Diliman, 1987

Academic Positions

Professor of Cultural Anthropology, Mindanao State University
Chair, Department of History, MSU (1975–1976)
Vice Chancellor for Research and Extension, MSU (since 1992)
Director, Southern Philippines Center for Peace Studies (1981–1984)

Public Service

Commissioner, Organic Autonomy Law for Muslim Mindanao (1980s)
Founding Chair, NCCA Sub-Commission on Muslim Communities

Fellowship and Recognition

Folklore Fellow, Finnish Academy of Sciences and Letters (1991)
Postdoctoral Nonviolence Fellow, Inter-University Center for Postdoctoral Studies, Dubrovnik (1983)
Governor's Award, Rotary International District 387 (1989)
Meritorious Award (1990)
Listed in *Marquis Who's Who*

Selected Works

The Muslim Filipinos: A Book of Readings (1981)
Possibilities for Peace in Southern Philippines (1990)
The Sarimanok in Myths and Living Tradition (2000)
Mindanao (1999)

ACADEMIC CAREER AT MINDANAO STATE UNIVERSITY

Madale spent the core of his professional life at Mindanao State University in Marawi City, one of the few institutions whose geographic and cultural positioning made it possible to produce scholarship about the Meranaw people from the inside.

He served as Chair of the Department of History from 1975 to 1976, and as Director of the Southern Philippines Center for Peace Studies from 1981 to 1984, at a time when the Moro insurgency and the consequences of the Marcos dictatorship made peace studies anything but an abstract academic enterprise.

He later rose to the position of Vice Chancellor for Research and Extension, a role he held from 1992 onward, giving him institutional authority to shape how MSU engaged with the communities surrounding it.

In the classroom, he introduced generations of students to what was then a relatively unusual combination: ethnography, indigenous epistemology, and conflict resolution theory, taught together as an integrated body of knowledge rather than separate disciplines.

Tales from Lake Lanao and Other Essays (2001)
Maranao (2002)

Notability

Pioneering Maranao cultural anthropologist, peace educator, and author; first chair of the NCCA Sub-Commission on Muslim Communities; founder of the *School for the Living Tradition*; recognized by Marquis Who's Who as a noteworthy university administrator and anthropologist.

Known For

Documenting Maranao oral literature and indigenous cultural traditions; bridging Islamic heritage and modern peacebuilding; co-founding the Access Philippines Youth Leadership Training Program; shaping the organic autonomy law for Muslim Mindanao.

His core argument, repeated across his lectures, publications, and public addresses, was that a durable peace in Mindanao could not be engineered from outside but had to be built on the foundation of local knowledge systems: the *salsila* (genealogical traditions), the oral epics, the customary protocols of *taritib*, and the Islamic values of the Meranaw and other Bangsamoro peoples.

CONSTITUTIONAL AND POLICY WORK

In the 1980s, Madale served as one of 53 commissioners tasked with drafting the organic autonomy law for Muslim Mindanao, the legal architecture that would eventually give rise to the Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (ARMM).

His contribution was not primarily technical but substantive: he argued, and helped ensure, that cultural identity, indigenous governance traditions, and the distinct historical experience of Muslim Filipinos were properly reflected in the language and structure of that law, rather than being subordinated to the homogenizing logic of the central state.

He was also appointed Regional Consultant Commissioner, further extending his policy influence into the mechanisms of regional governance.

NATIONAL CULTURAL GOVERNANCE

Madale served as the founding chair of the Sub-Commission on Muslim Communities under the National Commission for Culture and the Arts (NCCA).

In that role, he established the *School for the Living Tradition*, a national program designed to address the accelerating loss of endangered indigenous crafts, music, performing arts, and oral traditions by pairing master practitioners with younger students in structured apprenticeships.

The program operated on a simple but powerful premise: that the most effective way to preserve a living tradition is not to archive it but to transmit it, person to person, across generations, within the communities where it originally lived.

He also authored the *Maranao* monograph (2002), published as part of the NCCA's *Katutubo: Profiles of Philippine Cultural Communities* series, providing one of the most authoritative brief introductions to Meranaw society and culture available to a general Philippine readership.

ACCESS PHILIPPINES AND INTERFAITH PEACEBUILDING

One of Madale's most consequential contributions to Mindanao peacebuilding grew out of a relatively modest starting point: a small peace research grant from the International Peace Research Association (IPRA) Foundation for a project he called "Buddy Buddy for Peace."

That initial grant, focused on documenting a model for interfaith dialogue, eventually became the springboard for a much larger initiative, the Access Philippines Youth Leadership Training Program, which he coordinated in partnership with the Center for Southeast Asian Studies at Northern Illinois University and the U.S. Department of State's Bureau of Educational and Cultural Affairs.

The program ran for at least six consecutive years, recruiting young adults and adult leaders from Mindanao's three communities: Muslims, Christians, and Lumad (indigenous peoples).

Qualified participants were brought to Northern Illinois University in DeKalb, Illinois for a one-month intensive training in peace, mediation, and conflict resolution.

After returning to Mindanao, participants implemented small community peace projects, then assembled three months later for a follow-on gathering to share results and discuss challenges.

In Madale's own words, the program "was responsible for the establishment of a network of youths and adults in Mindanao for peace and development."

He also noted that the original IPRA research grant gave his office the opportunity to document a model for interfaith dialogue that, in the post-September 11 environment, became a widely used case study in peace studies programs across the region.

LITERARY AND ANTHROPOLOGICAL WORKS

Madale's bibliography spans several decades and ranges from academic monographs to cultural essays accessible to general readers.

His foundational anthology, *The Muslim Filipinos: A Book of Readings* (1981), offered an insider's account of the history, identity, and social institutions of Muslim communities across the Philippine archipelago, at a time when such perspectives were largely absent from mainstream Philippine publishing.

Possibilities for Peace in Southern Philippines (1990) gathered his political essays on how traditional Islamic concepts and indigenous frameworks for reconciliation could be applied to the Mindanao conflict, a contribution that anticipated many of the arguments that would later shape formal peace negotiations.

The Sarimanok in Myths and Living Tradition (published by Cagayan Capital College, 2000) is arguably his most distinctive work: a deep scholarly investigation into the iconic mythical bird of the Maranao people, tracing its origins across multiple epic traditions and clarifying its ritual, symbolic, and artistic functions within Meranaw society.

In his *Sarimanok* research, Madale cross-examined competing origin stories, including the connection to Prince Radia Indarapatra in the Maranao epic *Darangen*, and meticulously parsed where authentic Meranaw tradition diverged from later accretions or popular retelling.

His monograph *Mindanao* (1999) and his NCCA-published *Tales from Lake Lanao and Other Essays* (2001) brought Meranaw mythology, folklore, and oral literature to a wider public, translating the richness of traditions like the *Darangen* epic cycle and the *Kashawing* rice ritual into prose accessible beyond the academic community.

His chapter-length essays on "The Future of the Moro National Liberation Front as a Separatist Movement in Southern Philippines" (1984, published by the Institute of Southeast Asian Studies, Singapore) and "The Resurgence of Islam and Nationalism in the Philippines" (1986, same publisher) remain standard references in Southeast Asian studies and in the academic literature on the Bangsamoro question.

ADVOCACY AFTER THE MARAWI SIEGE

Following the 2017 Marawi Siege, which devastated the city where Madale was born and spent his career, he became a vocal advocate for integrating peace education into the core school curriculum for the Bangsamoro region and across Mindanao.

His argument was consistent with the logic of his entire scholarly career: that rebuilding Marawi required more than physical reconstruction, that the real work was healing young minds, countering the narratives of violent extremism with deep cultural literacy, and restoring the sense of Meranaw identity and dignity that the siege had disrupted.

He contended that the most durable counter-narrative to radicalization was not political messaging but the living cultural heritage of the Meranaw people itself, including its oral epics, its customary law, its art forms, and its Islamic ethical tradition.

RECOGNITION AND LEGACY

Madale was listed in *Marquis Who's Who* as a noteworthy university administrator and anthropologist.

He received the Governor's Award from Rotary International District 387 in 1989, followed by a Meritorious Award in 1990.

His family includes his wife, Milagros A. Pabular (married April 6, 1968), and seven children: Namil, Faridah, Zuraydah, Fatima, Nagasura Junior, Rajah, and Amir.

His legacy is difficult to reduce to a single category because his life's work deliberately refused those categories.

He was an academic who wrote policy, a cultural preservationist who built peace programs, a Meranaw insider who engaged with Finnish folklorists and Yugoslav nonviolence scholars, and a storyteller who believed that the epics of Lake Lanao were not museum pieces but living instruments for navigating conflict, building identity, and imagining a better future for Mindanao.

The *School for the Living Tradition*, the Access Philippines network, the *Sarimanok* scholarship, the organic autonomy law framework, and the dozens of students he trained at MSU are all, in their different ways, continuations of that single coherent project.

SEE ALSO

- Marawi City
- Mindanao State University
- Maranao people
- Darangen
- National Commission for Culture and the Arts (Philippines)
- Bangsamoro Organic Law
- Moro National Liberation Front
- Lake Lanao

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